ESSENTIAL LECTURE 05

Basic Image Editing and Graphic Composition

Combine images, shapes and text into a readable event notice

Layers • Hierarchy • Layout • Export

TUMAINI COMMUNITY

LEARNING CENTRE



What you will be able to do

This lesson uses a prepared illustration to build one clear digital event notice.

01 ORGANISE

Recognise the role of layers, name them clearly and arrange objects in the correct order.

02 DESIGN

Combine one image, a few shapes and editable text using clear spacing and hierarchy.

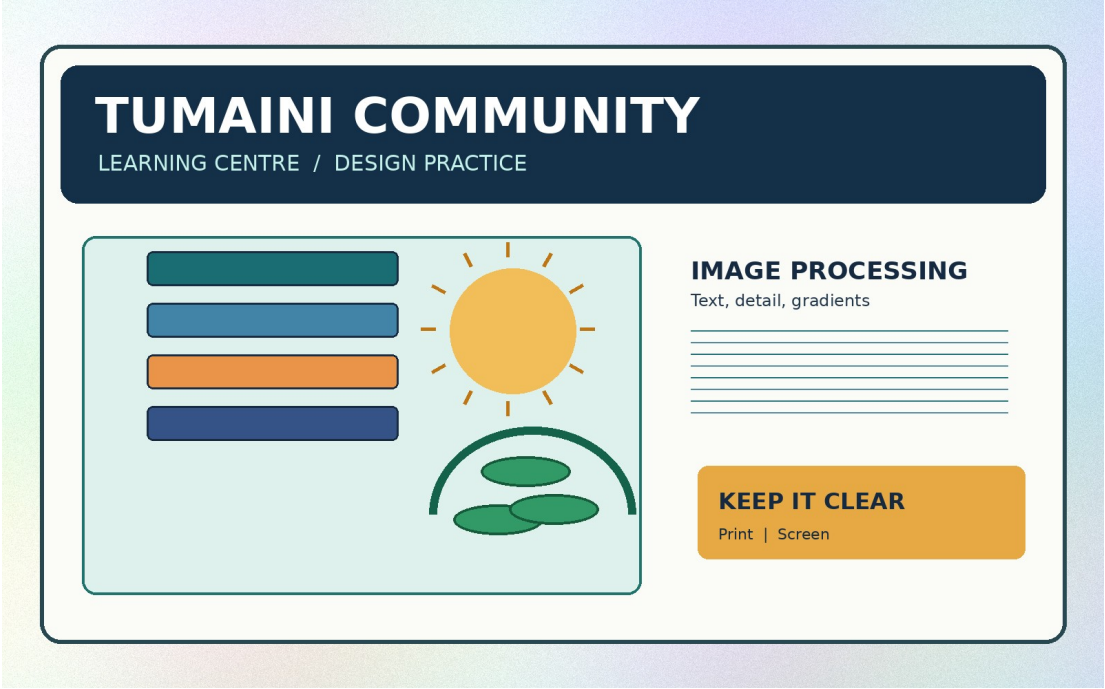
03 DELIVER

Save an editable Photoshop project and export a final image that can be checked and shared.

The goal is a readable publication—not a display of every Photoshop effect.

You already have the first ingredient

Lecture 4 taught how to prepare an image. Now use it in a small composition.



One running project

Tumaini Community Learning Centre needs a simple digital announcement for its fictional “Stay Safe Online” session. Keep the main title, image and event details easy to find.

What is a graphic composition?

Every element should help the reader understand one message.

Definition

A graphic composition is a planned arrangement of text, images, shapes and empty space within a defined area. It communicates more effectively when the elements have clear relationships.

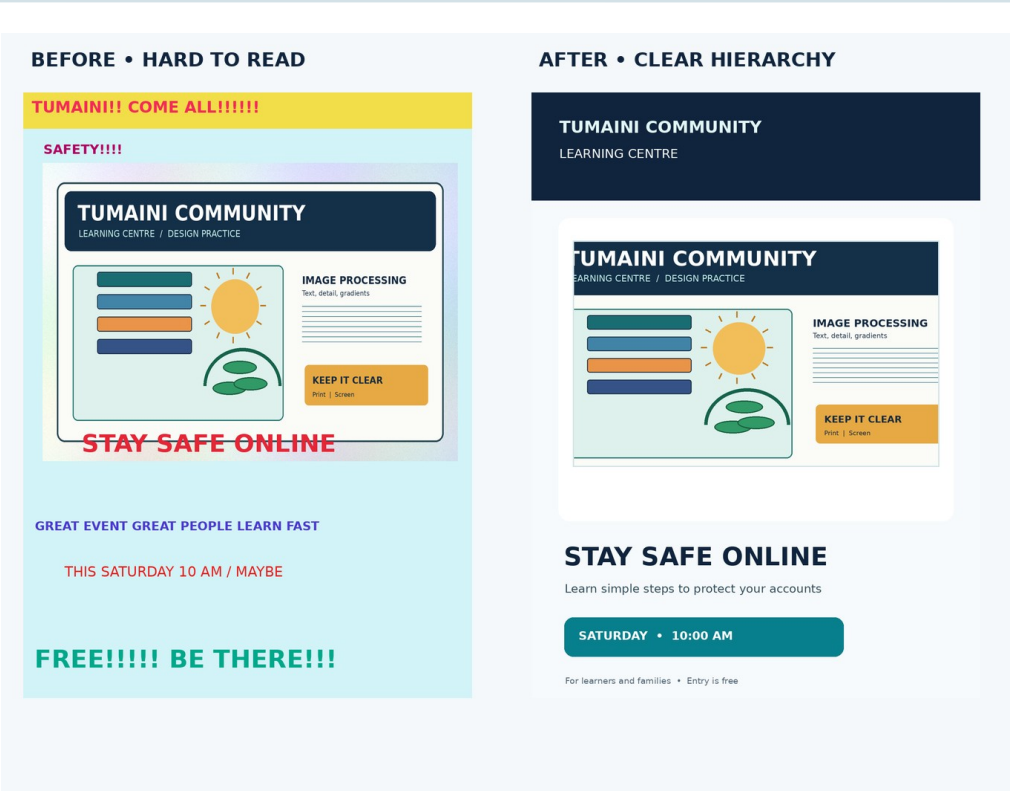
Example

An event notice combines an illustration, a prominent session title, a short explanation and a visible date/time. Random decorations that interrupt this sequence do not improve communication.

A composition is effective when readers know where to look first, second and third.

Why some notices are difficult to read

Look for poor hierarchy, crowding, alignment and colour choices.



Which works better?

A design can contain the correct facts but still communicate badly. The clearer notice uses a stronger title, calmer colours, consistent margins and a distinct place for the date and time.

Students should justify their judgement using design principles.

A layer is an editable part of the page

Layers make a complex graphic easier to revise without rebuilding everything.

BACKGROUND

The base colour or image behind the design. Often kept at the bottom of the stack.

IMAGE

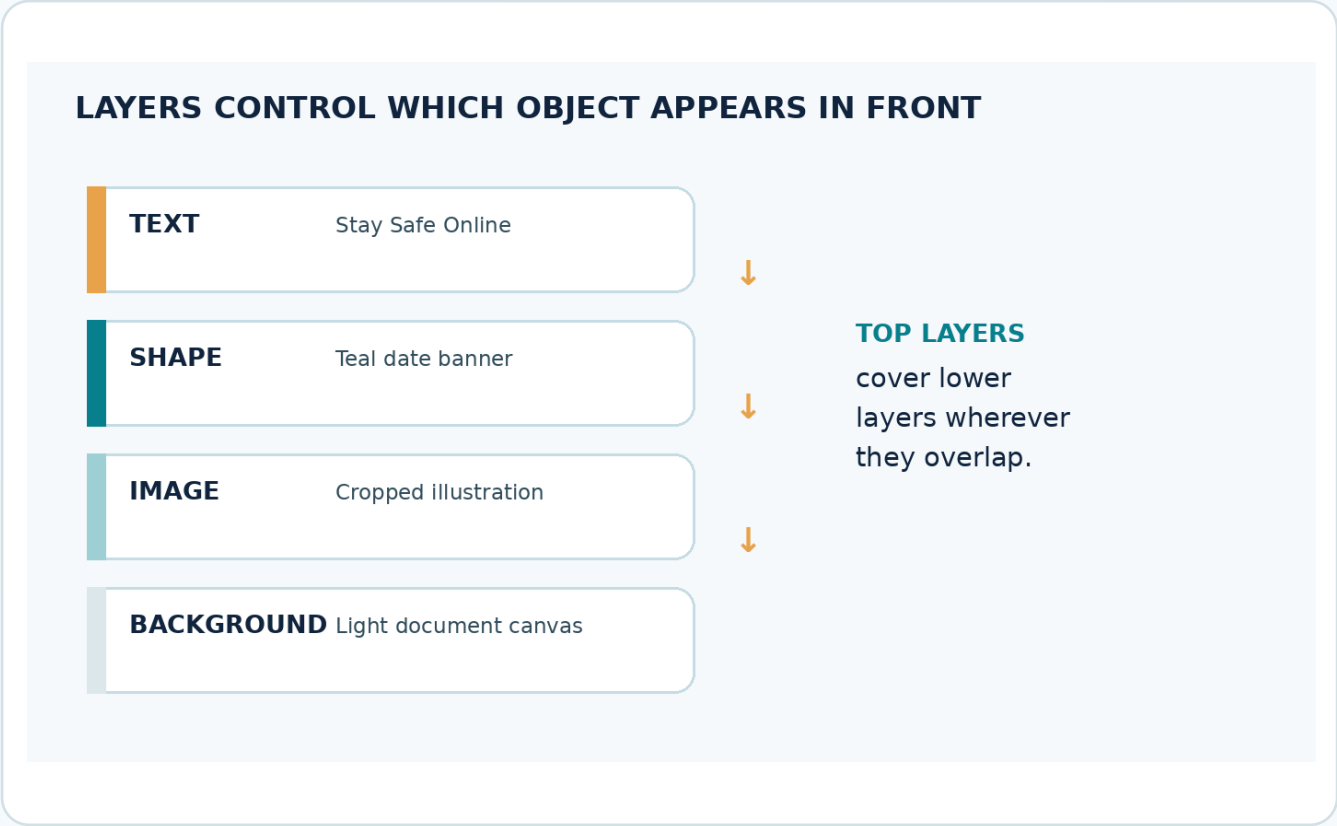
A placed illustration or photograph that can be resized and repositioned separately.

TEXT + SHAPES

Headlines, descriptions and coloured banners that remain independent of the image.

The order of layers changes what you see

The highest visible layer generally appears in front where objects overlap.



Think of stacked sheets

If your title disappears behind a photograph, inspect the Layers panel. Move the title layer above the image layer rather than redrawing the heading.

The top item is visually in front where it overlaps lower items.

Why keep separate layers?

One decision can be changed without disturbing unrelated elements.

MOVE

Change the position of the event title while leaving the photograph exactly where it is.

REPLACE

Swap a background picture without retyping the event details.

REVISE

Correct an incorrect date on its own text layer, then produce an updated export.

Use meaningful layer names

Clear names make an editable file useful after the lesson.

Hard to work with

Layer 1
Layer 1 copy 2
Rectangle 5
Text copy 3
Layer 8

Easier to understand

Background
Cropped photo
Date banner
Main heading
Event details

Rename layers as the composition grows; do not wait until the end.

Find the Layers panel in Photoshop

It usually lists each visible component and provides common layer controls.

EYE ICON

Temporarily show or hide a layer to identify what it contains.

ORDER

Drag layers to change front-to-back order when they overlap.

LOCK + NAME

Protect a background from accidental movement and rename important layers.

Make one simple document

The example dimensions support digital teaching—not every type of print job.

Start a portrait canvas

Use File > New and enter approximately 1000 × 1350 pixels. Save the new PSD before you begin arranging objects. In other editors, use an equivalent custom-size document.

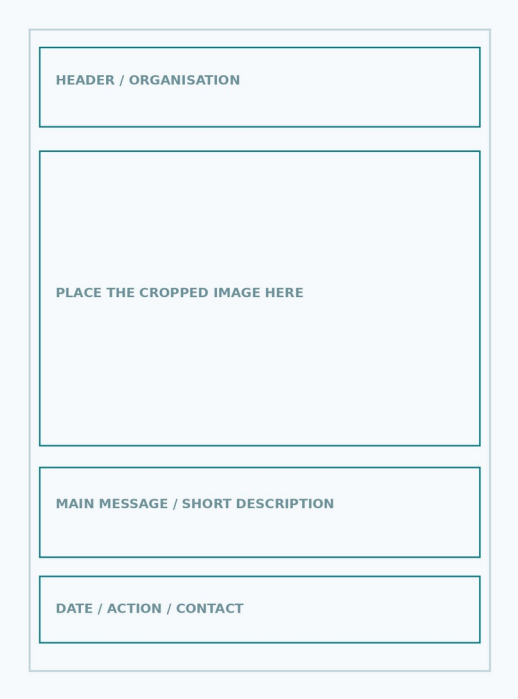
Why choose dimensions first?

The document dimensions describe the working area. Changing them late can disturb object positions. Use a different size if the publication's real output requires one.

Keep the original source image stored separately, exactly as in Lecture 4.

A layout can start as a simple sketch

You do not need specialised design skills to plan where objects belong.



Four useful regions

Reserve space for the organisation name, a relevant image, the main event title and a date/action line. Use the template as a guide; the final design should be your own editable document.

Place the image on its own layer

A separately placed image is easier to move or scale.

Practical sequence

1. Open the new document.
2. Choose File > Place Embedded (or equivalent).
3. Select the prepared Tumaini image.
4. Resize proportionally and confirm.
5. Name the layer “Photo”.

Look for these problems

Do not stretch the picture to fill a frame. Do not cover an important face, icon or word. A picture that already fits naturally may be better than a tightly cropped image.

In different Photoshop versions, commands and toolbar positions may vary.

Placing is not the same as flattening

Keep the image and text independent until the project is finished.

PLACE IMAGE

Add the picture as a separate component, then scale and position it.

EDIT SOURCE

Make necessary crop or tonal changes in a working copy when practical.

DO NOT FLATTEN

Avoid merging every layer before you have saved the editable project.

Use the Type Tool for editable words

A heading should be easy to change if details are corrected.

Headline

Create “STAY SAFE ONLINE” as a separate text layer. Make it visually prominent, use a readable typeface and keep enough clear space around the letters.

Supporting text

Use smaller text for the workshop description and a clear line for date/time. The reader should not need to guess which detail matters most.

Avoid rasterising text: rasterised words are no longer directly editable as characters.

Show readers what to read first

Readable hierarchy is created with size, spacing, position and contrast.



Three clear levels

The large heading attracts attention, a medium-sized statement explains the event, and smaller text gives the date and practical information. Keep the type styles consistent.

Use one type family and only a few deliberate size differences.

A simple hierarchy has a purpose

Each level answers a different question for the reader.

LEVEL 1: WHAT?

STAY SAFE ONLINE

The central topic of the notice; bold and immediately visible.

LEVEL 2: WHY?

Learn simple steps to protect your accounts.

A short explanation in smaller readable text.

LEVEL 3: WHEN?

Saturday • 10:00 AM

Practical detail separated clearly from the description.

Shapes are useful when they organise information

A rectangle can be functional rather than decorative.

BANNER

Place a coloured rectangle behind the date when it improves legibility.

BACKGROUND

Use a restrained pale shape to separate the main message from a busy image.

ACCENT

A small line or circle can indicate a section, but should not compete with the title.

How to add a banner without creating clutter

A restrained shape should support the text above it.

Basic procedure

Choose a shape tool, draw a rectangle, apply a modest fill colour, move it below the date text in the layer stack and check that the words remain legible.

Common mistake

An oversized or overly bright shape may attract more attention than the event title. Reduce its size, contrast or number of colours until the information is easier to scan.

Alignment gives the composition structure

Related elements should share a clear visual edge or centre.



Compare the margins

The right-hand design aligns the heading, image and supporting line. Consistent edges help the eye move from one element to the next without unnecessary searching.

Intentional alignment is more important than perfect symmetry.

Spacing can explain relationships

Objects that belong together should appear grouped together.

PROXIMITY

Keep the date and time close enough to be read as one piece of information.

WHITE SPACE

Leave breathing room between the title, image and supporting information.

MARGINS

Keep important text away from the outer edges of the notice.

Choose colours that keep words readable

Colour is useful only when the contrast is sufficient.

Reasonable choices

Dark navy words on white or pale backgrounds often read clearly. A teal banner can work with white text if the contrast is strong enough at the final viewing size.

Avoid weak combinations

Pale yellow text on white, bright red words on green or multicoloured decorative backgrounds may make reading difficult. Check the result on a small screen as well as on your computer.

Do not rely on colour alone to communicate a required fact.

Before adding a new effect, ask one question

Does it make the message easier to understand?

KEEP

A clear title, readable date, helpful picture and restrained shape.

REDUCE

Too many colours, inconsistent text effects and unrelated icons.

REMOVE

Decorations that overlap text or make the image harder to understand.

What does non-destructive editing mean?

It means keeping choices reversible rather than damaging your only source.

Simple beginner method

Duplicate the image layer before testing changes. Keep the original beneath it, then hide or delete the copy if you dislike the result. Your source remains available.

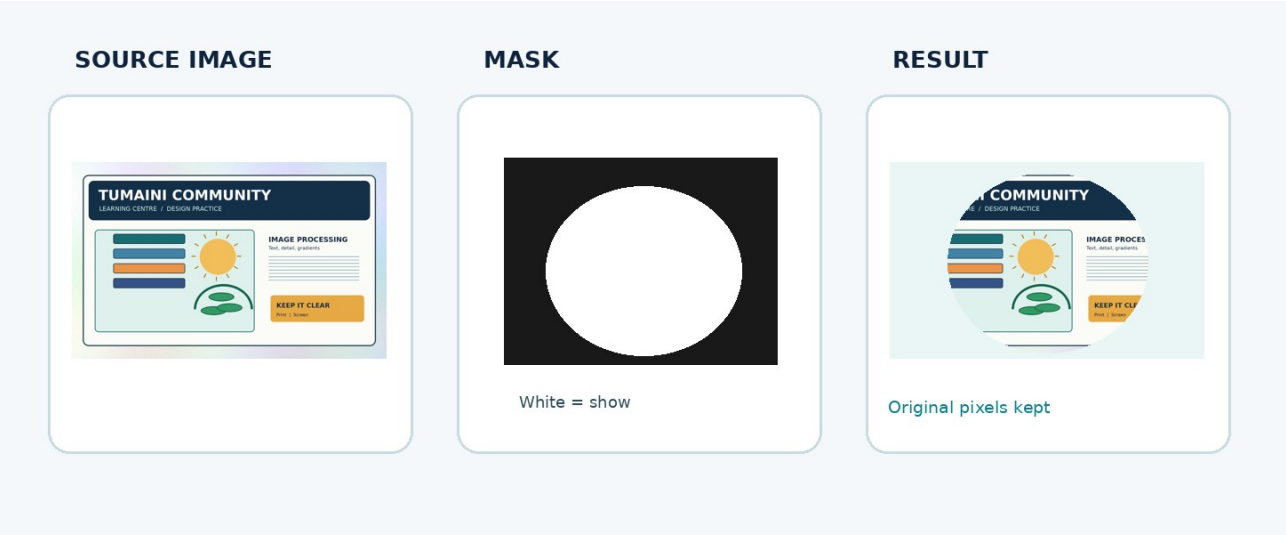
Another method: layer masks

A mask hides or reveals parts of a layer without erasing those pixels permanently. Detailed selections are optional for this condensed practical.

You do not need an advanced mask to complete a simple rectangular picture layout.

A layer mask controls what is visible

For a normal mask: white reveals the image, black hides it.

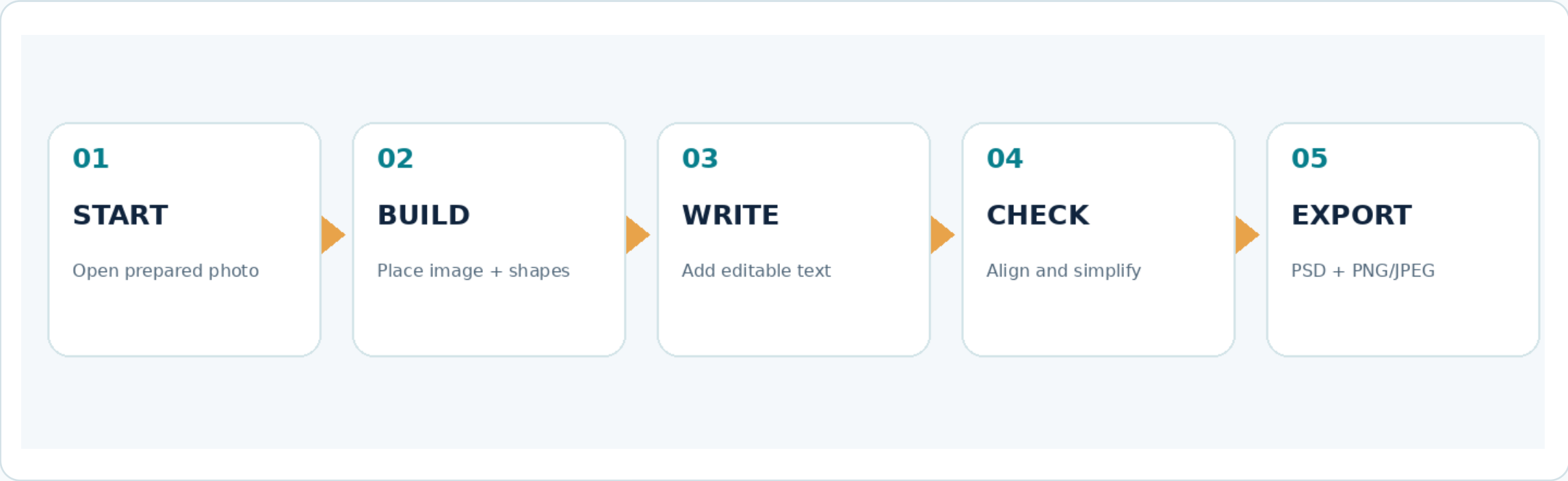


The pixels remain

A mask changes the visibility of part of a layer rather than permanently deleting that part of the source image. For this course, understand the idea; complex hair or edge selections are extension practice.

A five-stage workflow is enough

Use a repeatable routine rather than experimenting with many unrelated commands.



Save the PSD before exporting; then inspect the finished image outside Photoshop.

Step 1: start and save a working project

Use the same folder arrangement developed in Lecture 4.

Open a new document

Create a portrait document of about 1000 × 1350 pixels. Save as 02_Working_Files/tumaini_event_notice.psd. Do not overwrite the original illustration.

Place the illustration

Use the supplied cropped Tumaini picture. Scale it proportionally and leave space for a heading and a date banner. Keep it on a named image layer.

Step 2: write the message

Use the provided copy rather than inventing detailed event information.

ORGANISATION

Tumaini Community Learning Centre

Small but clearly visible at the top.

MAIN TITLE

STAY SAFE ONLINE

A prominent heading with strong contrast.

SUPPORTING DETAILS

Learn simple steps to protect your accounts
Saturday • 10:00 AM

Keep the two lines readable.

Step 3: improve the arrangement

Small changes to spacing and alignment often matter more than special effects.

ALIGN

Use a consistent left or centre line for the main components.

SEPARATE

Keep the title, image and date distinct enough to scan.

CHECK

View the poster at reduced size. If the date is hard to read, improve it.

Step 4: make the file easy to revise

Your layers should tell the next person what the document contains.

Suggested layer structure

Headline
Date banner
Photo
Background

Place elements in a sensible order for the design.

What to preserve

Editable text, correctly scaled image and an organised background. Avoid unnecessary rasterising or flattening before saving the PSD.

The exact layer order may differ if objects do not overlap; preserve readability.

Step 5: export the finished notice

Keep the editable project separate from the copy intended for sharing.

Editable project

Save tumaini_event_notice.psd in Working_Files. Reopen or inspect it and confirm that the main text and image layers can still be edited.

Exported file

Export tumaini_event_notice.png or .jpg into Exports. Reopen it outside the editor. Check text, colour, event time, picture and cropping.

A good design still needs a final check

The intended audience sees the exported file, not your Layers panel.

ACCURACY

Is the title correct? Are the date and time clear and consistent with the supplied brief?

READABILITY

Can the heading and date be read on a phone or when the slide is shown smaller?

FILE QUALITY

Does the export open properly? Is the PSD still available for revisions?

Solve the common problems first

Most beginner problems have a straightforward cause.

TEXT DISAPPEARS

Check whether the text layer is hidden or below an opaque image.

IMAGE STRETCHES

Undo the change and resize with proportions constrained.

DATE IS UNREADABLE

Increase contrast or type size; reduce clutter and retest at smaller size.

Your short independent practical

Build one clear notice; do not spend the whole session on decorative effects.

Minimum checklist

- ☐ Prepared source image used
- ☐ Main heading and supporting text
- ☐ Separate text, image and shape layers
- ☐ Clear hierarchy, contrast and margins
- ☐ Editable PSD file saved
- ☐ PNG/JPEG export reopened and checked

What to submit

One editable event notice, one exported image and a short written explanation of two design decisions. When software is unavailable, sketch the layered design now and complete the digital file in practical time.

Can you answer these questions?

Use the notes and diagrams to explain, not just list, the concepts.

QUESTION 1

How does changing the position of a layer affect overlapping objects?

QUESTION 2

Explain how hierarchy, alignment and spacing work together in a notice.

QUESTION 3

What is the difference between a Photoshop PSD and a PNG/JPEG export?

TAKEAWAY

Keep the design simple and editable

The message is more important than the number of tools you used.

Image + Shapes + Editable Text + Space

Good composition guides attention, preserves editability and produces a clear final export.

NEXT: Create simple scalable artwork using vector graphics.